

Formal and Informal Tone of Writing

BY: ADNAN AHMED

“Good technical writing is not about sounding intelligent; it is about being understood.” (MIT OCW)



Understanding Tone in Professional Writing

What is Tone?

Tone refers to the writer's attitude toward the subject and the reader, conveyed through:

- ✓ Word choice
- ✓ Sentence structure
- ✓ Level of formality
- ✓ Use of personal voice

Understanding Tone in Professional Writing

In technical & business writing, tone must always support:

- ✓ Clarity
- ✓ Professionalism
- ✓ Purpose

Guess the tone!

“This report evaluates the feasibility of implementing an AI-based recommendation system. The analysis covers technical requirements, data availability, and system integration challenges.”

“This report assesses the feasibility of adopting an AI recommendation system. The findings suggest that the system is technically viable and financially beneficial, with potential to improve customer engagement.”

“We’ve completed the initial testing phase, and the results look promising. The system performed well under normal conditions, and we’re moving to the next phase.”



Formal Tone

When to Use Formal Tone:

- ✓ Technical reports
- ✓ Feasibility reports
- ✓ Research papers
- ✓ Proposals
- ✓ Executive summaries

Formal Tone

Example (Formal – Technical Report):

“The experimental results indicate that the proposed model achieves an accuracy of 92%, outperforming existing approaches under identical conditions.”

Informal Tone (Controlled Informality)

An informal tone is conversational but still professional. It does not mean casual or careless.

Characteristics:

- ✓ Simple sentence structure
- ✓ Active voice
- ✓ Friendly but respectful language

Informal Tone (Controlled Informality)

When Informal Tone is Acceptable:

- ✓ Emails within teams
- ✓ Progress updates
- ✓ Internal memos
- ✓ Some digital communication

Informal Tone (Controlled Informality)

Example (Informal – Workplace Email):

“We tested the updated model this week and saw a noticeable improvement in response time. I’ll share the detailed results by Friday.”

Note: Informality should never reduce clarity or credibility (MIT OCW).

Technical vs Business Audiences

Technical Audience	Who they are:	What they expect:	Writing Style:
	✓ Engineers ✓ AI developers ✓ Data scientists ✓ Researchers	✓ Technical accuracy ✓ Methodology ✓ Data and evidence ✓ Detailed explanations	✓ Formal ✓ Technical vocabulary ✓ Structured logic

*“The convolutional neural network was trained using a dataset of 50,000 labeled images with data **augmentation** (make or become greater in size or amount) applied to reduce **overfitting** (when a model fits too closely or even exactly to its training data).”*

Technical vs Business Audiences

Audience	Who they are:	What they expect:	Writing Style:
	✓ Managers ✓ Investors ✓ Administrators ✓ Policy makers	✓ Purpose and outcomes ✓ Cost and benefits ✓ Risks and feasibility ✓ Recommendations	✓ Clear and concise ✓ Minimal technical jargon ✓ Decision-oriented

“The proposed AI system will reduce processing time by 30%, leading to lower operational costs and improved customer response rates.”

Same Information, Different Audiences (MIT OCW Core Principle)

Technical Version:

“The model utilizes **gradient boosting** (*an MLT that builds a strong predictive model by sequentially combining many weak models to correct errors*) with optimized **hyperparameters** (*controls the learning process and model architecture*) to improve predictive accuracy.”

Business Version:

“The improved model provides more reliable predictions, helping the organization make better data-driven decisions.”

Sample Writing 1: Formal Technical Writing (Report Excerpt)

“This report evaluates the feasibility of implementing an AI-based recommendation system. The analysis covers technical requirements, data availability, and system integration challenges.”

- ✓ Clear purpose
- ✓ Formal tone
- ✓ Audience-aware
- ✓ Structured

Sample Writing 2: Business Writing (Executive Summary)

“This report assesses the feasibility of adopting an AI recommendation system. The findings suggest that the system is technically viable and financially beneficial, with potential to improve customer engagement.”

- ✓ Focus on outcomes
- ✓ No technical overload
- ✓ Decision-oriented

Sample Writing 3: Informal Professional Communication

“We’ve completed the initial testing phase, and the results look promising. The system performed well under normal conditions, and we’re moving to the next phase.”

- ✓ Friendly but professional
- ✓ Clear and concise
- ✓ Suitable for internal updates

Common Mistakes

- ✓ Using technical jargon for non-technical audiences
- ✓ Being too casual in formal documents
- ✓ Mixing tones within one document
- ✓ Writing without a clear audience in mind

Personality test:
If you enter this room,
which chair would you sit in?

Pick a chair, I'll reveal who you are.

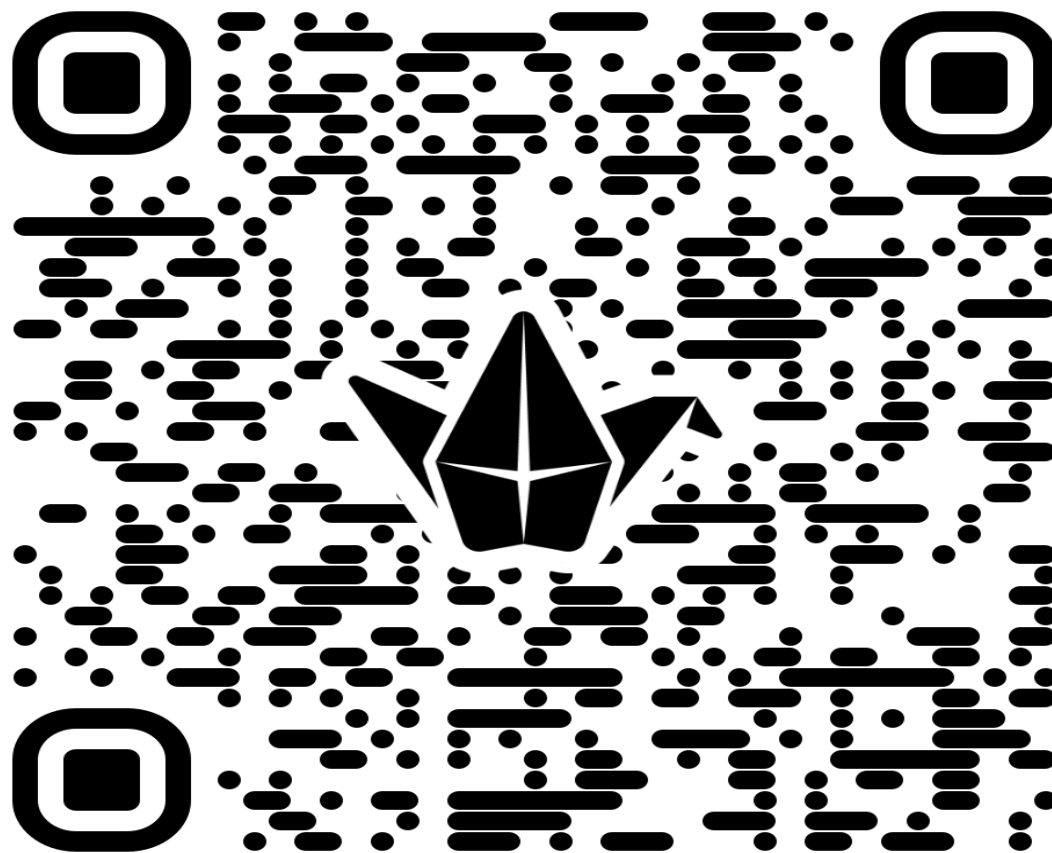


Classroom Activity

“The AI model achieved a significant improvement.”

- ✓ For a technical report
- ✓ For a business proposal
- ✓ For an email to a team member

Scan to access!

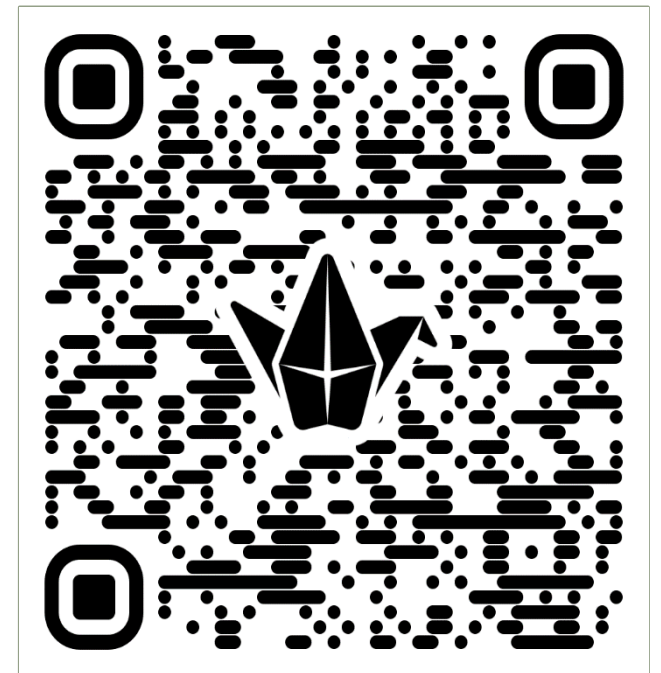


References

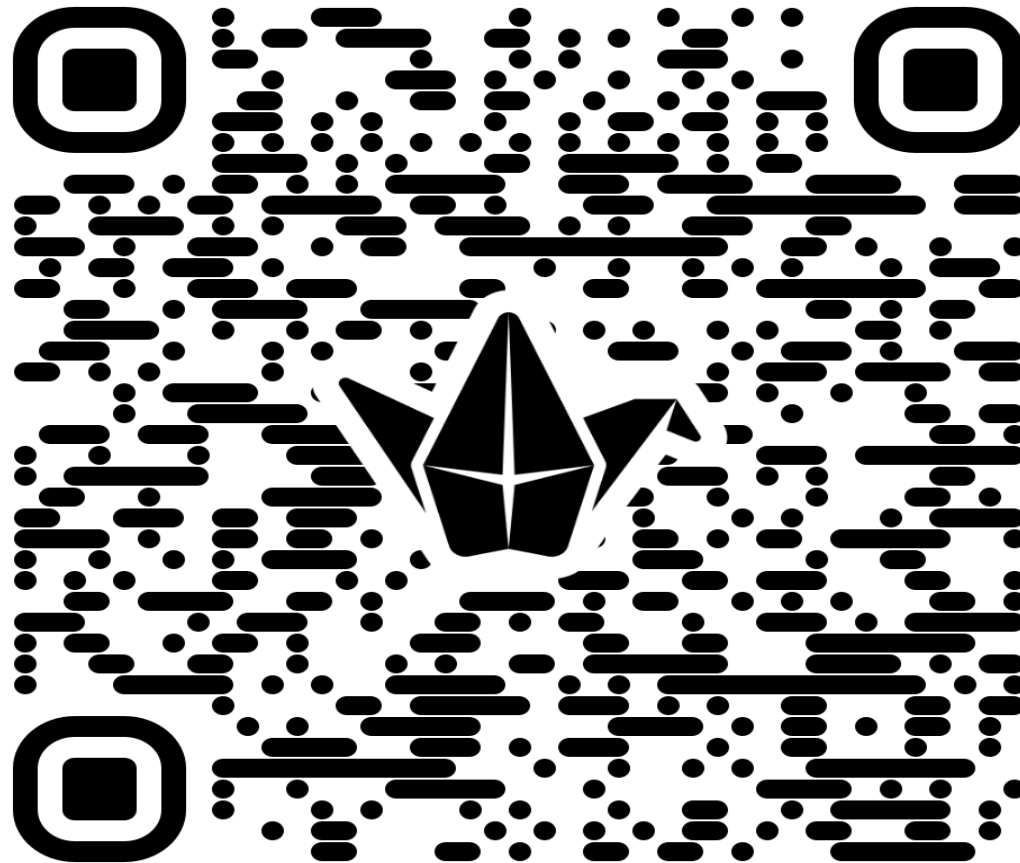
- Gerson, S. J., & Gerson, S. M. (2000). *Technical writing: process and product*. 3rd ed. Prentice Hall.
- <http://web.mit.edu/writing/>
- <https://www.perplexity.ai/>

Task:

- ✓ Organizational Patterns in Writing
- ✓ Ethical Standards, Ethical Issues, and Consideration of Ethics in Technical Communication
- ✓ Cultural Context in Technical and Business Writing
- ✓ Plain Language, Avoiding Verbosity and Jargon
- ✓ Audience Analysis, Anticipation, and Adaptation



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THANKS.

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